

Net-zero impact on the aquifer?

The Green Paper's reason for leaving WSC's boreholes out of groundwater licensing, tested

THE CLAIM

“...the Corporation is moving towards the achievement of a net-zero impact on the groundwater environment...”

Energy and Water Agency, Green Paper on groundwater abstraction, Nov 2023

Same page: WSC abstraction “will be capped at a maximum level of 14 Mm³ up to 2030”.

A proposal in a consultation document; we did not find whether it was adopted.

PLEDGE

NOT MEASURABLE

*No definition,
no date.*

NOT
MEASURABLE

NOT YET
DUE

ON
TRACK

OFF
TRACK

MET

MISSED

MAIN RESULTS

11.5

million m³ in 2025

WSC groundwater production: 82% of the proposed 14 million m³ cap, and 15% below 2016.

+4%

Cap above 2016

The ceiling sits only 4% above the highest year we read (13.5 million m³ in 2016).

13%

New Water vs abstraction

Treated wastewater supplied in 2022 (1.6 million m³) against what WSC abstracted (12.7).

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Aquifers in poor quantitative status

Including both main sea-level aquifers (EU reporting, assessed 2021).

No balance

Nothing published

No source we read sets out what is given back, measured how.

FAIR TO SAY

WSC's share of groundwater in its supply fell from 42% to 29% since 2016, and the cap is met so far. Lower abstraction and reuse are sound aims; the question is whether 'net zero' can be checked.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ A definition, baseline and date for 'net-zero impact'.

☐ Annual New Water volumes and where they are used.

☐ Whether the cap and exemption were adopted.

☐ Any estimate of recharge from the networks.